



- 1** New Delhi's Bhu Kombucha offers the drink in nine flavours at ₹250 a bottle
- 2** Goa-based Latambarcem Brewers sells the Borécha brand of kombucha; mango flavour is their biggest seller
- 3** Raw Kombucha is available in both bottles (₹99 for 250 ml; six flavours) and cans (₹110 for 250 ml; three flavours)

THE GLOBAL KOMBUCHA MARKET IS ESTIMATED TO GROW TO \$9.60 BILLION BY 2030 FROM \$2.71 BILLION IN 2021

"The fermentation produces a beverage rich in antioxidants, digestive enzymes, good bacteria and amino acids," he says. The final product contains less than 1 per cent sugar.

"Kombucha is a fermented food, full of antioxidants and probiotics that helps boost gut health and improve our immunity, making the body more efficient," says Kavita Devgan, a Delhi-based nutritionist and author of books such as *The Don't Diet Plan* and *The Immunity Diet*. "Better gut health also helps one lose weight and cut inflammation in the body, which helps cut the risk of multiple disorders," she adds.

But in the end, it all boils down to taste. "Our mango flavour is our biggest seller," says Ashraf Ahmed, Marketing Lead at Goa-based Latambarcem Brewers, which sells the brand Borécha (meaning good tea in Konkani). The company, founded by brothers Ishan and Aneesh Varshnei, also manufactures Maka Di Beer.

They started brewing kombucha in 2020 when having returned from the US, they were unable to find any kombucha brands in India. Today Borécha is available pan-India in six low-sugar and four zero-sugar varieties in 330 ml cans (₹160). While their low-sugar flavours (containing 3 gm of sugar per 100 ml) such as mango and Hawaiian passion fruit contain probiotics, the zero-sugar flavours such as Fiji fruit punch contain prebiotics. The brand is available pan-India through online retail and at F&B outlets and airports in metro cities such as Delhi NCR, Mumbai, and Bengaluru, amongst others. You can enjoy it on Akasa Airlines and it recently set up a vending machine at Ashoka University. "There is a growing demand among the young and health-conscious," says Ahmed.

According to market research firm The Brainy Insights, the size of the global kombucha market is projected to grow to \$9.60 billion by 2030 from \$2.71 billion in 2021,

at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 15.1 per cent. The growth is primarily due to the adoption of a healthy lifestyle.

So, is kombucha just a trend? "No, because it is about your gut health, and health can never be a trend," says 40-year-old Isha Singh Sawhney, Founder of Bhu Kombucha. The New Delhi-based company offers nine flavours (at ₹250 a bottle), including the best-selling apple and cinnamon, and apricot. Sawhney started brewing kombucha at home in 2017 for herself after her uncle carted a batch of SCOBY for her from the US. "I think of myself as an accidental entrepreneur," she laughs. A year later, she started stocking it at organic cafes in Delhi and slowly the business grew. Today Bhu is available in grocery stores and cafes in Mumbai, Pune, Goa, Lucknow, and Bengaluru, amongst others. She also has three collaborations, including with wellness resort Ananda in the Himalayas for whom she brews a special kombucha, which is honey fermented instead of sucrose.

With a large number of other players such as Happy Booch, Atmosphere, Khukrain's Kombucha, etc., supplying in different parts of the country, looks like the healthy fermented tea beverage is here to stay. **BT**

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